



# HERBALISM COURSE MODULE 1

## Introduction

Herbalism, or phytotherapy, is the art and science of using plants and herbs for therapeutic purposes. The term *phytotherapy* comes from the Greek words *phyton*, meaning "plant," and *therapein*, meaning "to heal." It is one of the oldest forms of healthcare and continues to serve as the foundation of many modern medical treatments.

In fact, of the 252 drugs classified as essential by the World Health Organization (WHO), 11% are derived exclusively from plants. Many others are produced through semi-synthesis, a process in which natural plant compounds are chemically modified to enhance their effects. A well-known example is the early contraceptive pill, which was developed using steroidal hormones derived from wild yam (*Dioscorea mexicana* and *Dioscorea composita*), later converted into synthetic progesterone.

It's important to note, however, that in nature these compounds exist as part of a complex synergy. The renowned physician Paracelsus once noted, "It took a great deal of time to perfect," referring to the natural balance plants have refined over millennia. When compounds are isolated, this natural synergy is often lost. For this reason, herbalism often favors the use of the whole plant (*totum*) to support long-term health, as it tends to be better accepted by the body.

In this course, you'll get to know over 50 medicinal plants and explore how to benefit from their full potential. We'll cover their traditional uses as well as practical ways to bring them into everyday life. As herbalists, it's our responsibility to help others use plant remedies safely and wisely, with a clear understanding of both their benefits and possible risks.

### ★ Activity

If you have medications at home, gather them and take note of their ingredients. Begin by researching each one to understand the ailments they are designed to treat, as well as any contraindications and potential side effects. Take note of this information and revisit it later in the course to explore which plants might offer similar functions or even complement these medications.

## Why Herbalism Matters More Than Ever

In today's world, the human body faces a host of new challenges; working in cities and offices, exposed to pollution, pesticides, and chemical fertilizers, and the declining nutritional quality of our food. As a result, our natural defenses have weakened, and certain plants that once offered healing may cause harm if not approached with care.



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At the heart of herbalism is the belief that prevention is the foundation of good health. True well-being depends not only on use of plants, but also on quality sleep, regular physical activity, and a wholesome, balanced diet. As an herbalist, your role is to help others make meaningful lifestyle choices that strengthen the body's natural defenses. Many of nature's most effective medicines are found in simple, everyday foods like vegetables, meats, and fruits.

Of course, even with preventative care, everyday ailments still occur. Throughout this course, you'll learn a variety of remedies to support the body through common health concerns. These include rheumatism, arthritis, inflammation, menstrual and menopause related symptoms, skin conditions such as acne or sunburn, allergies, digestive disorders, depression, and postnatal recovery. Herbal medicine can also help regulate the nervous system, improve flexibility, and restore vitality for those who feel depleted or fatigued.

In a time of rising economic, environmental, and ethical challenges, and with increasing strain on global healthcare systems, turning to natural practices like herbalism is more important than ever. It calls for a return to balance and a renewed recognition of our deep connection with the natural world.

## Practicing Herbal Medicine

**A certified herbalist is neither a doctor nor a licensed healthcare professional** (unless they have undergone additional training and obtained qualifications in those fields). By law, they are not authorized to make diagnoses or prescriptions. They can, however, offer advice and recommend safe natural remedies available over the counter at pharmacies and health food stores.

Herbalists should be mindful of the language used in their practice. Unless they are licensed, they should avoid terms like "treatment," "medicine," or "prescriptions." Instead, they can discuss the properties of plants, such as antiviral or antifungal effects. It is also important to deepen their knowledge of human anatomy, the active compounds in plants, and how these compounds affect human health.

Many plant preparations (referred to as 'galenic forms'), such as dried and powdered plants, essential oils and mother tinctures, were traditionally sold by pharmacists. However, an increasing number of these are becoming available to the public through foragers, suppliers and wholesalers. Today, a wide variety can be found in stores and on websites specializing in natural products.

It's up to each individual to find out about the regulations governing medicinal plants in the country where they wish to practice herbalism. In the UK, a product is considered medicinal if it falls within one of two definitions: it is marketed with claims to treat or prevent disease in humans, or it can be used to restore, correct, or modify physiological functions, or to make a medical diagnosis. This is confirmed by the European Court of Justice.

It's worth noting that it's quite possible that all plants have a therapeutic effect, even if research is slow to prove it!

In addition to formal training, herbalists should continue their education through scientific study (suggested readings will be provided in Module 10). A thorough well-researched approach is essential both during and after this training. As you progress, you may choose to specialize in either a scientific

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or symbolic approach, or even combine both, creating a holistic practice that embraces the full spectrum of plant knowledge.

Herbalism can also complement other healing practices, such as osteopathy or massage therapy. For instance, herbal teas can provide ongoing support, or herbal infusions can enhance the effects of lithotherapy.

### ★ Rules and Regulations

To maintain high standards in their practice, herbalists should follow these 7 key rules of conduct:

1. Maintain precision and rigor, using the **correct Latin botanical names for plants**. While common and regional plant names can be helpful for everyday reference, it's important to recognize their limitations. These names can refer to multiple species, potentially leading to confusion. For example, the term "chamomile" may refer to Roman chamomile, German chamomile, or Wild chamomile. We'll cover this in more detail in the next module.

2. Use or recommend only **high-quality products**, such as organic or biodynamic options.

3. Familiarize yourself with the components and **natural compounds (active ingredients)** of plants, and consult "chromatographs" (GC/MS ratios) of essential oils.

4. Understand the specific **effects of plant compounds on organs**, systems, or functions within the human body.

5. Adopt a systematic approach that **considers the individual holistically** (i.e., their diet, lifestyle, etc.), examining the following aspects in each session (which we will explore in more detail in Module 3):

- The immediate cause (physical)
- The underlying cause (emotional/mental)
- The overriding cause (general life context)

6. Be mindful of the language used, opting for **non-medical terminology and offering advice** instead.

7. Stay vigilant about the **potential risks associated with plants** and always inform your clients accordingly.

## General Guidelines for Avoiding Plant Toxicity

Certain plants can be extremely toxic and even fatal when ingested, so they should only be used under professional supervision or avoided entirely. This is particularly important for vulnerable groups like pregnant or breastfeeding women, children, the elderly, and those undergoing medical care. For individuals receiving chemotherapy or radiotherapy, a waiting period of one to four weeks is typically recommended before introducing any herbal support, as it may interfere with treatment.

It's also important to suggest that clients conduct allergy tests to help prevent adverse reactions.

**Key toxic plants when ingested include:**

- ❖ Rosary pea (*Abrus precatorius*)

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- ❖ Aconite (*Aconitum* - all species)
- ❖ Sweet flag (*Acorus calamus*)
- ❖ Spring pheasant's eye (*Adonis vernalis*)
- ❖ Tree wormwood (*Artemisia arborescens*)
- ❖ Common wormwood (*Artemisia absinthium*)
- ❖ Dogbane (*Apocynum*)
- ❖ Dutchman's pipe (*Aristolochia*)
- ❖ Cuckoopint (*Arum maculatum*)
- ❖ Belladonna (*Atropa belladonna*)
- ❖ Autumn crocus (*Colchicum autumnale*)
- ❖ Jimsonweed (*Datura stramonium*)
- ❖ Foxglove (*Digitalis*)
- ❖ Mandrake (*Mandragora officinarum*)
- ❖ Pennyroyal (*Mentha pulegium*)
- ❖ Opium poppy (*Papaver somniferum*)
- ❖ Tansy (*Tanacetum vulgare*)
- ❖ Coltsfoot (*Tussilago farfara*)

Many herbs have side effects for two main reasons: long-term use or excessive intake. Always inform clients of these risks and encourage the use of low-dose remedies. The plant's effect on the body depends on the individual's needs, and even small amounts can be highly effective. To minimize risks, start with a recommended daily dose (provided in the descriptions of the 50 plants studied). When purchasing an herbal product, always read and follow the specific dosage instructions on the label.

Essential oils carry additional risks and should only be used according to proper guidelines. They should be used through inhalation or topical application and always well diluted. Extreme caution is required when using them with vulnerable groups. Some essential oils can be toxic to the skin (such as all citrus oils), neurotoxic, or even abortifacient (including sage and lemon verbena). For this reason, we recommended advising your clients to speak to a qualified physician regarding the use of mother tinctures for specific conditions.

**The following oils should be avoided for individuals with epilepsy:**

- ❖ Western red cedar (*Thuja plicata*)
- ❖ Common wormwood (*Artemisia absinthium*)
- ❖ Spiked wormwood (*Artemisia genipi*)
- ❖ African wormwood (*Artemisia afra*)
- ❖ Hyssop (*Hyssopus officinalis*)

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- ❖ Common sage (*Salvia officinalis*)
- ❖ Arborvitae (*Thuja occidentalis*)
- ❖ Pennyroyal (*Mentha pulegium*)
- ❖ Buchu (*Agathosma betulina*)
- ❖ Lesser calamint (*Calamintha*)
- ❖ Tansy (*Tanacetum vulgare*)
- ❖ Mugwort (*Artemisia vulgaris*)
- ❖ Camphor tree (*Cinnamomum camphora*)
- ❖ Boldo (*Peumus boldus*)
- ❖ American wintergreen (*Gaultheria procumbens*)
- ❖ Fragrant wintergreen (*Gaultheria fragrantissima*)
- ❖ Birch (*Betula*)
- ❖ Rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*)
- ❖ Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*)
- ❖ French lavender (*Lavandula stoechas*)
- ❖ Feverfew (*Tanacetum parthenium*)
- ❖ Aspic lavender (*Lavandula latifolia*)

**For those who are pregnant, breastfeeding or for babies, avoid these oils:**

- ❖ Anise (*Pimpinella anisum*)
- ❖ Birch (*Betula*)
- ❖ Black cumin (*Nigella sativa*)
- ❖ Carrot (*Daucus carota*)
- ❖ Cinnamon (bark) (*Cinnamomum zeylanicum*)
- ❖ Northern cypress pine (*Callitris intratropica*)
- ❖ Fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*)
- ❖ Camphor tree (*Cinnamomum camphora*)
- ❖ Hyssop (*Hyssopus officinalis*)
- ❖ Myrrh (*Commiphora myrrha*)
- ❖ French lavender (*Lavandula stoechas*)
- ❖ Oregano (*Origanum vulgare*)
- ❖ Common sage (*Salvia officinalis*)
- ❖ Lavender-leaved sage (*Salvia lavandulifolia*)

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❖ American wintergreen (*Gaultheria procumbens*)

❖ Fragrant wintergreen (*Gaultheria fragrantissima*)

### ★ Activity

Create a large poster-sized sheet of paper where you will compile a list of all the plants that pose risks. Draw three columns: one for the common name of the plant, one for the Latin name, and a third for the associated risks and cautionary doses. Add red dots next to the names of the plants that are particularly hazardous.

## Organizing Consultations

As we will emphasize throughout this course, it is essential to exercise the utmost caution and be mindful of the potential risks associated with certain plants. With this in mind, you can apply your knowledge of herbal medicine in various ways: offering guidance, conducting therapeutic sessions with plants, and recommending dietary plants that support health for varying durations.

### ★ For Each Consultation, You Should

1. Gain insight into the individual's background and history through a brief questionnaire.
2. Provide thoughtful, precise recommendations, including one or more remedies.
3. Monitor the effects of the advice given and be prepared to adjust the plant remedies as the situation evolves.

The questionnaire should cover the following points:

- **Personal Information:** Gather basic details like contact information, surname, first name, profession, and date of birth – all of which can provide context for understanding their concerns.
- **Reason for Visit:** Understand the main issue they hope to resolve with herbal remedies, whether it's personal interest, a friend's recommendation, or a specific problem they wish to address.
- **Medical History and Current Health Issues:** Gather information about past surgeries, allergies, ongoing medical treatments, or pregnancy.
- **Contact information of their general practitioner (GP):** This allows you to verify that the herbal remedies you recommend will not interfere with any existing medical treatments or conditions. You may also want to request an emergency contact, should urgent medical attention be required.

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- ➔ **Lifestyle:** Look into aspects like alcohol consumption, physical activity, diet, and sleep patterns. Herbalism often aims to alleviate chronic pain, improve sleep, or reduce stress, so lifestyle habits can guide your recommendations.
- ➔ **Psycho-Emotional State:** This helps to place their physical health concerns in a broader context, understanding how emotions or mental states might be affecting their well-being.
- ➔ **Client's Expectations:** Clarify what they hope to achieve from your herbalism advice, helping you tailor your approach accordingly.

## Example of an Introductory Questionnaire for an Herbalism Consultation

### ★ Identity

First name, last name:

Age:

Date and place of birth:

Address:

Phone number and email:

GP contact details (to be contacted to verify any current treatment):

Person to contact in case of emergency (first and last name with contact details):

What are you expecting from your Herbalism session or advice?

### ★ Health Profile

Current medical treatment (certain oils can suppress or increase the effects, even in the case of alternative medicine such as homeopathy):



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Surgeries, transplants, and dates:

Accidents, injuries, etc. (dates, conditions, and locations):

General health and comments:

### ★ Information Required for Women

Are you pregnant? If yes, how many weeks:

Do you have menstrual problems? If so, which ones?

### ★ Skin-related Information (for Choosing the right Vegetable/Carrier Oil, etc.)

What type of skin do you have (dry, oily, sensitive)?

Do you have any allergies?

### ★ Lifestyle

Daily water consumption (in liters/gallons or glasses):

Daily tea and coffee consumption (in cups):

Wine and alcohol consumption (in glasses per week): Alcohol may interfere with the effectiveness of herbal remedies:

Diet/eating habits:

Energy levels:

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Sleep:

Exercise/relaxation activities:

Physical posture (upright, hunched, etc.):

### ★ General Psycho-emotional State and Aromatic Preferences

How would you sum up your psycho-emotional state (motivation, desire, stress, mood, outlook)?

Which plants and scents are you most drawn to (fruits, flowers, roots, leaves...)?

### ★ Further Investigation of Health Conditions

Asthma, tumor, cancer, diabetes, heart problems, sclerosis (consult the doctor before recommending an herbal remedy):

Blood circulation problems (thrombosis, embolism, blood pressure):

Fever (avoid herbal remedy, or only recommend it with the doctor's consent):

Epilepsy (certain plants should be avoided):

Immunization (no remedy within 48 hours of vaccination):

Nervous system under treatment (always with the advice and consent of the doctor):

Hyperthyroidism (light herbal remedy to avoid over-stimulation):

Post operation (wait at least one week after a minor operation, and 1 or 2 months after a major operation):

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Chemotherapy and radiotherapy (with the doctor's approval and at a very low dose in all cases):

### ★ Special Conditions

Age (for children, it is important to obtain parental consent):

Other drug intake:

### ★ Activity

Begin by selecting a plant to focus on during this module, in any form. It could be one you already have at home, such as a flower from your garden, an herbal tea from your cupboard, or even a photograph of a plant. Take time to examine it closely and make notes on what you know, as well as what you'd like to learn. Record your personal observations – such as its name, color, scent, taste, and any effects you've experienced. Let your thoughts flow freely, without limitations or expectations.

## Herbs and Medicinal Plants - Knowledge Cards

To support your training and future practice, you can create a deck of 'Herbs and Medicinal Plants Knowledge Cards.' This deck will cover the 50 plants studied throughout the course, making it a handy reference for both learning and plant selection.

On the front of each card, include an illustration of the plant – either an image sourced online, or hand drawn yourself. Seeing the plant can enhance the effectiveness of the remedy, as it helps the individual connect more deeply with the plant. Before photography, botanists would meticulously sketch plants, a practice you can adopt as well.

On the reverse side of each card, leave space for a brief summary of the plant's key properties and uses. Alternatively, you can use a notebook with enough space beneath each illustration for your notes. This deck will also help you connect each plant to the body system it supports, which we will explore in detail across the 10 modules. Here's an overview of what's to come:

➔ Module 1 – Introduction to Herbalism, Skin, Tetraterpenes

Blackcurrant (*Ribes nigrum*)

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Nettle (*Urtica dioica*)

Astragalus (*Astragalus mongholicus* or *membranaceus*)

Gotu kola (*Centella asiatica*)

Aloe Vera (*Aloe vera*)

### ➔ Module 2 – History and Botany, Respiratory System, Amino Acids, Proteins, and Derivatives

Marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*)

Ceylon cinnamon (*Cinnamomum zeylanicum*)

Blue gum (*Eucalyptus globulus*)

Hyssop (*Hyssopus officinalis*)

Propolis (Propolis)

### ➔ Module 3 – Plants of the World: Ayurveda, Cardiovascular System, Lipids, and Fatty Acids

Garlic (*Allium sativum*)

Ginkgo (*Ginkgo biloba*)

Flax (*Linum usitatissimum*)

Olive tree (*Olea europea*)

Damask rose (*Rosa damascena*)

### ➔ Module 4 – Herbalism and Chinese medicine, Hepato-biliary System, Sesquiterpene Derivatives (Sesquiterpene Lactones)

Turmeric (*Curcuma longa*)

He Shou Wu (*Polygonum multiflorum*)

German chamomile (*Matricaria recutita*)

Rosemary (*Salvia rosmarinus*)

Milk thistle (*Silybum marianum*)

### ➔ Module 5 – Plant Mythology and the Doctrine of Signatures, Digestive System, Saponins

Pot Marigold (*Calendula officinalis*)

Cardamom (*Elettaria cardamomum*)

Licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*)

Peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*)

Dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*)

### ➔ Module 6 – Anthroposophical Method, Musculoskeletal System, Sugars, Carbohydrates, and Polysaccharides

Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*)

Arnica (*Arnica Montana*)

Frankincense (*Boswellia carterii*)

Horsetail (*Equisetum arvense*)

Ginger (*Zingiber officinalis*)

### ➔ Module 7 – Algae, Fungi and Lichen, Immune system, Phenolic Compounds

Iceland lichen (*Cetraria islandica*)

Echinacea (*Echinacea purpurea*)



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Reishi (*Ganoderma lucidum*)  
Chaga mushroom (*Inonotus obliquus*)  
Ginseng (*Panax ginseng*)

### ➔ Module 8 – Gemmotherapy, Urinary System, Monoterpene Derivatives

Silver Birch (*Betula pendula*)  
Fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*)  
Meadowsweet (*Spiraea ulmaria*)  
Mediterranean cypress (*Cupressus sempervirens*)  
Oak (*Quercus robour*)

### ➔ Module 9 – Bach Flower Remedies, Nervous System, Alkaloids

Valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*)  
St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*)  
Roman chamomile (*Chaemamelum nobilis*)  
Marjoram (*Origanum majorana*)  
Schisandra (*Schisandra chinensis*)

### ➔ Module 10 – Plant Intelligence, Reproductive and Endocrine Systems, Triterpene derivatives

Lady's-mantle (*Alchemilla glabra*)  
Lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*)  
Sage (*Salvia officinalis*)  
Anise (*Pimpinella anisum*)  
Clary sage (*Salvia sclarea*)

## Choosing a Plant – Quality and Other Factors

To select a high-quality plant, it's important to gather certain key details. Ideally, knowing the growers themselves or acquiring as much information as possible from trustworthy, reputable sellers. This includes details such as the plant's origin, harvest date, and cultivation methods. The following information should be readily available, either on the label or directly from the seller.

### ✪ The Plant's Botanical Name in Latin

Knowing exactly which species you're using allows for more precise and beneficial application. For example, *Eucalyptus globulus*, *Eucalyptus citriodora*, *Eucalyptus smithii*, and *Eucalyptus radiata* all belong to the same genus but possess distinct therapeutic qualities.

### ✪ The Plant's Country and/or Region of Origin

The active principles of a plant can vary depending on where and how it is grown. For example, a dull, brittle lemon verbena from Egypt may lack the freshness of a bright green lemon verbena grown in Brittany. The color difference often indicates how the plant was dried (careful shade-drying in Brittany versus sun-drying in Egypt). Generally, it's best to choose plants grown more locally, but don't limit yourself entirely, there are amazing plants from around the world that are now easily accessible!

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### ★ The Part of the Plant Used

The effectiveness of a plant varies greatly depending on which part is used, whether it's the root, leaves, flowers, fruit, bud, whole plant, or essential oil. Each part may offer different therapeutic benefits, or even opposite effects. Later, we'll explore how to select the right part to achieve desired results.

### ★ Expiration Dates

Always check expiration dates on your products as it is important to use fresh, high-quality dried plants. It is common practice to replace dried plants each year at the end of summer with new season harvests. The same goes for hydrosols, like rose or orange blossom water, which are used for gentle remedies and cooking. Mother tinctures have a long shelf life, but essential oils can oxidize over time and may irritate the skin. Citrus oils typically last around a year, flower and leaf oils for two to three years, while oils derived from roots and resins tend to last much longer.

### ★ Sourced Organically or Ethically

Whenever possible, gather your own plants from wild or cultivated areas that are free from pollution. If you need to purchase plants or plant-based products, prioritize those that are certified organic or, ideally, biodynamic (often marked with the Demeter label in Europe), or sourced from other environmentally conscious producers. While organic farming permits small amounts of certain chemical inputs, biodynamic farming follows stricter practices with greater consideration for environmental care. These high-quality plants often come at a higher price, reflecting the time, skill, and dedication involved in their cultivation.

### ★ Your Personal Taste

To assess the quality of plants, rely on your senses of taste, sight, and touch, similar to how you choose vegetables at the market based on their appeal. When selecting herbal teas made from fresh or dried plants, examine the roots and other components, and inhale the aromas of the oils before making a purchase.

### ★ Activity

Visit a health food store, pharmacy, or if available, a local herbalist's shop. Explore the range of plants offered and read their labels carefully, focusing on their origin, names, and any production methods. This will help you become more familiar with which plants you can use and how they are sourced. You can also do this activity at home using any herbal products you already have. Take notes on your findings.

## Advice from an Herbalist

A young pregnant woman comes to see you, expressing her growing concerns about using certain remedies or plants during her pregnancy. She is apprehensive about the potential effects and is seeking at least two or three safe plants to consider. How would you respond to her?

### ★ Recommended Answer

Several well-researched herbs are generally considered safe during pregnancy, such as ginger, which can help alleviate nausea, and others that support the digestive and nervous systems, including Roman chamomile, marjoram, lavender, orange blossom, and aloe vera. However, it is important to consult with a healthcare provider or a qualified herbalist specializing in pregnancy before trying any new remedies to avoid potential negative interactions. Additionally, selecting high-quality, organic products is recommended to minimize the risks associated with pesticides.

## A Human Body System: The Skin

Similar to plants and animals, the human body is made up of cells, which are the basic units of the living organism. These cells, composed of carbon, hydrogen, and nitrogen, form tissues that organize into structures like the skin and other body systems. Cells take in oxygen from the bloodstream, generating energy and supporting various biochemical processes.

The skin, the body's largest organ, consists of three main layers: the epidermis, dermis, and hypodermis. The epidermis, made of dead skin cells, acts as a protective barrier and varies in thickness across different areas of the body (e.g., thicker on the soles of the feet than on the ankles). The outermost layer of the epidermis, called the stratum corneum, is rich in keratin – a waxy substance derived from the Greek word *keras*, meaning "horn." This layer is thick, impermeable, and highly resistant, symbolizing the body's connection to the external environment.

## Plants for Skin Ailments

Skin diseases are often among the most perplexing in medicine and understanding them requires a holistic approach. Most skin problems, aside from sunburn and burns, are linked to factors such as diet, pollution, stress, and internal imbalances in the immune, neurovegetative or endocrine systems.

Plants can support skin health in two important ways: by soothing symptoms on the surface and by strengthening the internal systems. For example, drinking nettle tea can help detoxify the body and support organ function, while chamomile essential oil, diluted in calophyllum oil, can be applied topically to soothe irritated skin.

Below is a comprehensive list of plants that can help address a variety of skin issues.

- ❖ **Eczema** can manifest in several forms, often triggered by chemical exposure or food sensitivities such as dairy. To ease allergic reactions, consider herbs like echinacea, blackcurrant, and plantain (*Plantago major* or *Plantago lanceolata*). If eczema is related to high uric acid levels, European ash, and sarsaparilla (*Smilax officinalis* or *Smilax regelii*) can help. For dry eczema, cedar of Lebanon buds is particularly useful. Comfrey, marshmallow, St. John's wort and yarrow can support healing, soften the skin, and promote regeneration. Blackcurrant is beneficial for all types of eczema.
- ❖ **Psoriasis**, which presents with a distinct appearance, is believed to be triggered by emotional shock, trauma, infections, endocrine disruptions, or vaccinations, although the exact cause is not fully understood. The condition often improves with exposure to sunlight and vitamin D, as well as plants that support the emotional and psychological aspects. Consider lavender and lemon balm to soothe the mind, passionflower to promote sleep, and gentian and St. John's wort for managing depression. Additionally, draining plants such as dandelion can help regulate kidney function, which plays an important role in skin health.
- ❖ **Acne** often arises during puberty due to hormonal changes, particularly increased testosterone, which stimulates sebaceous glands. This condition typically involves liver and bile dysfunction. To support the liver and hormonal balance, herbs like artichoke, wild pansy, burdock, and dandelion are helpful. Clary sage, fennel, lady's mantle, and yarrow support the hormonal system. Many essential oils (diluted), such as tea tree and lavender, can also address acne, offering antimicrobial and anti-inflammatory benefits to the skin.
- ❖ **Burns** must be assessed according to type, as chemical burns may interact negatively with plant remedies. However, most plant oils, including sweet almond, rose hip, apricot kernel, argan, and calophyllum are beneficial for skin recovery. When combined with essential oils like lavender or calendula, these oils can accelerate healing. St. John's wort and calendula in mother tincture form (diluted in water) provide astonishing healing effects, while yarrow aids in faster skin repair.
- ❖ **Shingles and Herpes**, both viral conditions, are often linked to a weakened immune system caused by psychological stress, excessive sun exposure, or trauma. To strengthen the immune system, consider echinacea and thyme, as they support both immune and neurovegetative function. For the most effective relief, essential oils such as tea tree, niaouli, myrrh, lavender, and clary sage are recommended.
- ❖ **Fungal infections** respond well to essential oils such as aspic lavender, geranium bourbon, and citronella, which have strong antifungal properties.
- ❖ **Hives**, an allergic hypersensitivity reaction, can be soothed and alleviated with herbs like Blackcurrant, Lavender, Damask Nigella, Plantain, Tansy, and German Chamomile.

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### ★ Activity

Buy a bottle of calendula mother tincture from the pharmacy. Pour 30 ml (1 fl oz) into a dropper bottle and label it "Calendula." Keep it handy for treating cuts, mosquito bites, cracks, or blisters. A few drops on a cotton pad or compress can be used to disinfect, reduce inflammation, and promote healing. Make note of any observations as you use it.

## Advice from an Herbalist

A young woman comes to you, distressed about her lifelong struggle with eczema, which she feels is negatively impacting her life. Following cortisone treatment, she developed asthma and is now dealing with both conditions. She's unsure about the triggers of her eczema despite her efforts to identify them. What do you recommend?

### ★ Recommended Answer

For this young woman, a good starting point would be to eliminate dairy products from her diet, particularly cow's milk, and observe if this change makes any difference. Encourage her to observe her overall eating habits, as sometimes a single dietary change can significantly improve eczema.

Next, you can prepare an oil remedy and recommend herbal teas, mother tinctures, or powders like wild pansy or gotu kola. Mallow and marshmallow tea can also be soothing. Advise her to focus on cleansing the body, as eczema can be a sign that toxins are not being properly expelled. Depurative and diuretic herbal teas, such as those containing dandelion, burdock, or nettle, can help with this, along with blackcurrant bud remedies.

For topical care, a St. John's Wort oily macerate mixed with calophyllum oil (and baobab oil, if available) can offer relief. Adding a few drops of patchouli, myrrh, or palmarosa essential oils will support the healing process, depending on what seems most suitable for her skin.

Eczema often reflects deeper internal imbalances, manifesting on the skin as a sign of something that needs attention.

## Active Compounds: Tetraterpenes

A course in herbalism wouldn't be complete without covering the active principles of plants. You can either study the scientific aspects as you go along or leave them aside and come back to them later.

Tetraterpenes, or carotenoids, are molecules made up of 40 carbon atoms. They are known for their vibrant colors, which range from orange and yellow to red, and are primarily categorized into three groups:

1. Carotenes (e.g., beta-carotene) – these are purely hydrocarbon carotenoids without oxygen.
2. Xanthophylls – these contain oxygen and contribute to the yellow hues in various plants.
3. Apocarotenoids – these are derived from carotenoids through enzymatic cleavage.

Approximately 600 carotenoids have been identified in nature, with around fifty being significant in the human diet. Foods rich in carotenoids include yellow, orange, and red fruits and vegetables, such as carrots, sweet potatoes, and peppers. Interestingly, these pigments also play a role in the changing colors of leaves during autumn as chlorophyll breaks down, revealing the carotenoids underneath.

### ✪ Therapeutic Properties

Tetraterpenes protect the plant (and subsequently humans) from harmful radiation and provide antioxidant benefits. They are recognized as precursors to vitamin A and possess preventive properties against certain cancers, particularly skin and prostate cancers. Plants containing tetraterpenes include dandelion, marigold, carrot, capsicum, papaya, orange, peach, mango, apricot, saffron, and paprika.

## Five Plants

### ✪ Blackcurrant (*Ribes nigrum*)



**Blackcurrant (*Ribes nigrum*)**

**Blackcurrant** is a member of the **Grossulariaceae** family. It grows wild in northern Europe but is mainly cultivated in France.

**The active compounds** in blackcurrant include polyphenols, monomeric flavonols, oligomeric tannins, organic acids, monoterpenes, and sesquiterpenes found in the essential oils. The berries also provide fructose, minerals, citric and malic acids, and anthocyanin pigments similar to bilberry. In addition, it contains a higher vitamin C content (particularly the juice) than lemons (about 4% of their total composition). Additionally, the seed oil is abundant in omega-6 and omega-3 fatty acids.

**History and mythology:** Its name is derived from the Arabic term "ribas," meaning "acidic-tasting currant." Historically, Indigenous Americans and Russians used blackcurrants to produce wine and



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alleviate conditions like constipation. In Europe, its medicinal properties weren't recognized until the 16th century, when it was notably used for viper bites and later associated with longevity.

**Therapeutic properties:** It is rich in antioxidants, promotes detoxification and adrenal function, and supplies vitamins that support the immune system. Its strong diuretic properties help cleanse the organs and support the health of the bowels, joints, and skin.

### The Parts Used

- Leaves, prepared as an infusion to aid elimination, particularly of excess water in the body (uretic acid and urea). They can also help reduce inflammation associated with conditions like edema, cellulite, gout, arthritis, arteriosclerosis, and hypertension. Blackcurrant is often recommended for the elderly to manage rheumatism (an herbal tea each evening) and to slow the degeneration of tissues. It can be combined with other diuretic plants such as birch, meadowsweet, ash, or willow.
- Berries, baked, infused, or decocted – for addressing sore throats, angina, digestive issues, eyesight problems, and diarrhea.
- Buds, for adrenal stimulation and anti-inflammatory action (superior to that of leaves)
- Mother tincture.
- Hydrosol.

**Dosage:** It is recommended to infuse 2 to 4 g (0.07 to 0.1 oz) of leaves in 150 ml (5 fl oz) of boiling water, steep for 5 to 10 minutes, and drink between meals or before bedtime. For bud macerate, take one teaspoon in the morning. For the hydrosol, use one tablespoon per day, diluted in a bottle of water.

**Toxicity and contraindications:** While blackcurrant is generally safe to use, it may not be recommended for individuals with renal or cardiac insufficiency. Additionally, due to a lack of extensive research, it is advised that pregnant women and young children avoid its use as a precaution.

### Activity

You can now add this plant to your 'Herbs and Medicinal Knowledge Cards' deck, highlighting its key characteristics. Be sure to include the common name, Latin name, botanical family, few active compounds, potential uses, and any associated risks.

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### ★ Nettle (*Urtica dioica*)



*Nettle (Urtica dioica)*

**Nettle** is a member of the **Urticaceae family**. It grows wild in phosphate and nitrogen-rich soils in temperate climates. Nitrogen is crucial for leaf development, while phosphorus supports root growth and flowering. The stinging agent is found in the hairs of the oval leaves.

**The active compounds** in Nettle include flavonoids, phenolic compounds primarily found in the roots, and organic acids such as formic acid (which contributes to itching), caffeic acid, and acetic acid. Additionally, nettle contains vitamins, amines (like histamine, choline, acetylcholine, and serotonin), and a significant amount of minerals, along with a high concentration of chlorophyll.

**History and mythology:** Nettle was found in the remedies of Hildegard of Bingen, who used it for stomach disorders and the elimination of toxins. Farmers also gave it to horses in cases of colic. Nettle continues to be the most widely used natural fertilizer by farmers wanting to respect the environment.

**Therapeutic properties:** It is highly nutritious (iron, calcium, and essential amino acids), but its main assets are its hemostatic, digestive, diabetic, purgative, and diuretic properties. It also stimulates the liver, spleen, and pancreas. Its silica content is said to have an effect on the metabolism, making it more luminous. Nettle is particularly beneficial for those feeling low or in need of an energy boost, especially during the short days of winter.

### ★ The Parts Used

- Root decoction, to help reduce dandruff and promote scalp health (with vinegar).
- Leaves in infusions, for purgative and diuretic effects.
- Seeds, for urinary incontinence.

**Dosage:** For a root decoction, use 50 g (1.75 oz) of root per liter (about 1 quart) of water to support dandruff and scalp health. For added benefit, combine with vinegar as a hair rinse. For leaf infusions, steep a handful of leaves in hot water and drink one cup two to three times per day. For seeds, chew up to one tablespoon in the morning at breakfast with honey or another preferred substance.

**Toxicity and contraindications:** It is not recommended in cases of edema or pregnancy. Infusions consumed in excess can cause gastric irritation. Seeds should not be consumed by pregnant or breastfeeding women.

### ★ Activity

You can now make the card for this plant in your Knowledge Card Deck. Always specify the common name, Latin name, botanical family name, some of the active compounds, uses, and possible risks.

### ★ Astragalus (*Astragalus mongholicus* or *membranaceus*)



**Astragalus** (*Astragalus mongholicus* or *membranaceus*)

4. 5. **Astragalus** belongs to the **Fabaceae family** and is native to China and Mongolia. It should be distinguished from other species of astragalus, which are known to be toxic to livestock and are native to the mountains of Iran and Iraq.

**The active compounds** are triterpenoid saponins, flavonoids, polysaccharides, phytosterols, and amino acids.

**History and mythology:** It has a long history of use in Chinese medicine, where it is known as *Radix Astragali* in the pharmacopeia of the People's Republic of China, specifically referring to the root. Traditionally, it is highly regarded for its ability to strengthen Qi (vital energy) and invigorate the blood.

**Therapeutic properties:** Astragalus is a tonic for the immune and cardiovascular systems, offering diuretic, hypotensive, and antioxidant benefits. It supports recovery from illness, stimulates appetite, and is valued in skincare and scalp care for its nourishing and vasodilatory properties. Often recommended as complementary support during cancer treatment (under medical supervision), it also helps the body combat viral infections, eliminate pus, manage rhinitis and excessive sweating, and support convalescence (particularly after blood loss). Additionally, it promotes tissue repair, relieves chronic diarrhea and extreme fatigue, and helps restore strength after surgery or hemorrhage.

### 🌀 The Parts Used

- Root decoction, to drink directly or use on the skin and scalp.
- In powder form, in capsules or loose for ingestion.

**Dosage:** The minimum daily dose in powder form is 5 g (0.2 oz). It is recommended to take 10 to 30 g (0.35 to 1 oz) per day, either as a decoction to drink regularly or as an external application in skincare or scalp treatments.

**Toxicity and contraindications:** It should be avoided during acute episodes (as it may worsen symptoms). Like all medicinal plants, it should be used in moderation (do not exceed a decoction of 30 g or 1.1 oz per day). While it can be taken over an extended period, it's best not to use it excessively for too long.

### Activity

You can now add this plant to your Knowledge Card Deck, highlighting its key characteristics. Always specify the common name, Latin name, botanical family name, some of the active principles, uses, and possible risks.

### ★ Gotu Kola (*Centella asiatica*)



*Gotu Kola (Centella asiatica)*

**Gotu kola** is a member of the **Apiaceae family**. As its botanical name suggests, it originated in Asia, but now grows in the humid climates of most tropical countries, notably Madagascar. It takes a lot of time and care to harvest it.

**The active compounds are** triterpene saponins (centellosides), madecassosides and asiaticosides, monoterpenoids and sesquiterpenoids (myrcene, germacrene, caryophyllene and pinene), flavonoids, and kaempferol glycosides.

**History and mythology:** Gotu kola has been used in Ayurvedic medicine for thousands of years. In Sanskrit, its name means "from Brahma", the Hindu deity who is said to have created the universe. It is still used today in many Asian culinary traditions for its aromatic, spicy and sweet taste. It has only recently made its way into Western herbal medicine but is beginning to attract more and more research into its many properties. "Gotu kola" means "cup-shaped leaf", and it originates from Sri Lanka. According to Ayurveda, gotu kola is one of the most rejuvenating plants. In China, it was (and still is) used for all skin diseases and injuries.

**Therapeutic properties:** It is anti-inflammatory, tonic, depurative, sedative, digestive, and calming. When applied topically, it supports the healing of ulcers, psoriasis, eczema, wounds, scars, chronic rheumatism, sunburn, and wrinkles. It is commonly used to firm mature skin and to reduce the appearance of cellulite, varicose veins, venous insufficiency, and stretch marks. Additionally, it is believed to boost circulation and, according to recent research (Malaysian Journal of Medical Sciences, 2016; *Frontiers in Pharmacology*, 2021), may have neuroprotective and neuroregenerative effects. It is also known to enhance memory and concentration and serves as a valuable remedy for stress and nervous system imbalances.

### ★ The Parts Used

- Fresh or dried leaves in the form of an infusion to be taken internally or externally. The fresh juice and decoction can be used on the skin or added to cosmetic creams and oils.
- Liquid plant extract or capsules for internal use.
- Powder to add to cosmetics and soaps. Note that the leaves are preferable to powder.
- As an oil macerate, infuse the plant in carrier oil (e.g. corymbia calophylla oil) and apply topically to the skin.

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**Dosage:** The minimum daily dose in powder form is 3 g (0.1 oz). As an infusion, it is recommended to use 1 to 2 teaspoons of dried leaves in 1 cup of boiling water, steeped for 10 to 15 minutes. This can be consumed up to three times daily.

**Toxicity and contraindications:** Gotu kola is non-toxic. However, excessive use may occasionally cause mild gastrointestinal discomfort or skin irritation.

### Activity

You can now add this plant to your Knowledge Card Deck. Be sure to include the common name, Latin name, botanical family, few active compounds, potential uses, and any associated risks.

### Remedy

Create a calming and slimming herbal tea for a friend who wants to lose weight but is also dealing with work-related stress and anxiety-related skin breakouts. Combine the following dried herbs: 20 g (0.7 oz) of gotu kola, 20 g of nettle, and 10 g (0.35 oz) of blackcurrant. Try the infusion yourself first and note any effects you experience.

### Aloe Vera (*Aloe vera*)



Aloe Vera (*Aloe vera*)

**Aloe vera** is a member of the **Asphodelaceae family**. The plant originated in southern and eastern Africa, but is now found in all the hot, dry climates of the Americas, Asia, and southern Europe. Aloe vera can reach heights of up to 4 meters (13 feet).

**The active compounds** are in the gel and juice when the leaf is cut. They include anthraquinones (such as alonin) and anthracene derivatives in the latex, as well as resins and essential oils. The inner gel contains polysaccharides, amino acids, lipids, enzymes, vitamins, and minerals.

**History and mythology:** It seems that Aloe Vera was used as an aperitif by the Mesopotamians, while the Egyptians used it for enemas, with the exception of Cleopatra, who used it for beauty treatment. It was combined with myrrh and applied to heal skin pathologies, sunburns, and other burns. Hippocrates advised burning it to prevent the spread of the plague. It was also used to assist digestion and reduce inflammation. In Ayurveda, aloe vera is called "kumari", meaning "vitality of youth". For the Chinese, it is a symbol of immortality.

**Therapeutic properties:** Aloe vera has depurative, digestive, laxative, healing, pituitary, and thyroid regulating actions. It is used to help prevent skin cancer and for its regenerative, anti-inflammatory, antifungal, and antibiotic properties. Externally, it is commonly applied as a gel for chilblains, chapped skin, sunburn, burns, insect bites, skin inflammation, corns (similar effect as arnica), and stretch marks. Aloe vera is especially effective for psoriasis, soothing redness and offering anti-inflammatory relief. It can also protect the skin from radiation during radiotherapy. Internally, aloe vera purifies the organs, supports those with chronic constipation, and strengthens intestinal flora. Furthermore, it stimulates appetite, making it useful for individuals with anorexia, and helps combat anemia, particularly in young women.

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### 🌿 The Forms Used

- ➔ Powders, juices, capsules, and mother tinctures for internal use as laxatives and purgatives.
- ➔ Gel for direct application to the skin or as toothpaste.

**Dosage:** The minimum daily dose is 20 mg (0.0007 oz) in the form of dried juice powder. Up to 200 mg (about 0.007 oz) can be used as a laxative.

**Toxicity and contraindications:** Aloe is non-toxic, but is contraindicated during breast-feeding and pregnancy, as high internal doses may have abortifacient effects. It can also act as an emetic. Aloe is not recommended for children under 12 years of age. Individuals with intestinal disorders, hemorrhoids, or women who are menstruating should avoid it, as it may stimulate blood flow and worsen symptoms.

### 🌿 Activity

You can now create a card for this plant as part of your 'Knowledge Card' deck, noting the main information. Be sure to include the common name, Latin name, botanical family, a few active compounds, uses, and any possible risks.

### 🌿 Pro Tip: Aloe Vera

If you're on vacation in a country where aloe vera grows and you've accidentally gotten extremely sunburned, try cutting off a branch and applying the gel to your skin to rehydrate, soothe, and heal your epidermis.

## Advice from an Herbalist

A 65-year-old woman seeks advice on alleviating her rheumatism. During your conversation, she mentions feeling deprived of sunlight, frequently feeling cold, and being prone to winter viruses. She is also concerned about her aging skin, which appears dull due to the gray city environment. Despite trying various remedies, she dislikes bland herbal teas and finds the smell of valerian particularly unpleasant. What would you suggest?

### 🌿 Recommended Answer

Plants with diuretic properties immediately come to mind, to relieve her rheumatism and eliminate uric acid. Since she prefers flavorful options, blackcurrant is ideal due to its natural sweetness, as opposed to the bitterness of nettle. Blackcurrant will also provide her with essential vitamins to boost her immunity during winter. To enrich the blackcurrant leaf tea, consider adding 2–3 nettle leaves and a touch of birch, which also offers a pleasant taste.



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For her skin, recommend using calendula or St. John's wort macerated oil. These oils can bring a sense of warmth and radiance while rejuvenating her skin. They are also ideal for massaging painful areas, thanks to their anti-inflammatory properties. However, advise caution with sun exposure, as these oils can be dermocaustic and may increase skin sensitivity.

Finally, recommend diffusing lavender essential oil to bring comfort during the harsh winter months.